LECTURE 2: BARRIERS TO EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION

Introduction

Welcome back to Lecture 2. In the previous lecture, we looked at the introductory aspects of communication skills. We looked at the meaning of communication and how various elements interact during the process. The purpose of communication was also examined. In addition, we also discussed the nature and characteristics of communication. We also observed that communication is a complex process and noise interferes with the communication process. In this lecture, we will focus on the barriers to communication and ways to overcome these barriers. Before we talk about the barriers to communication, take a minute to reflect:

Have you had a misunderstanding with someone because you misunderstood his or her message? Why does communication breakdown happen and what can you do to avoid it?

Sometimes, we are not able to communicate clearly because of barriers (also called 'noise') which often can get in the way of effective communication hence stopping us from sharing and understanding messages. A critical step in learning how to improve your communication skills is knowing the barriers to effective communication.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

By the end of this module, you should be able to:

1. Describe the principles of effective communication
2. Explain why communication breaks down
3. Identify barriers that interfere with effective communication
4. List strategies for improving communication

Principles of Effective Communication

There are important principles that ensures effective communication. Let us therefore study some important principles of effective communication.

1. Clarity- It is the clarity of thought and expression.
    (a) Clarity of thought: This is important when the idea is being generated in the mind of the sender. At this stage, three points should be checked upon.

One is supposed to be clear about the objective of the communication. This begins with the generation of an idea in the mind of the transmitter. The writer should be able to answer:

i) What is the objective of writing?
ii) What is to be communicated? For example a song, play, poem etc.
iii) Which medium is appropriate for the purpose of communication? For example, letters

(b) Clarity of expression

The following points deserve attention.

i) Use of simple words- simple words is more effective than heavy words.
ii) Use concrete expression- these provide visual images which are easy to register so instead of vague generalized statements give definite facts.
iii) Prefer active construction- these are easy to understand other than passive i.e. in passive form " your report will be discussed by the committee'' but in active form ''the committee will discuss your report''
iv) Avoid excessive use of infinitive
v) Avoid jargon- these are special languages of a trade or a profession
vi) Avoid ambiguity- this is where a word has more than one meaning
vii) Use short sentences- short sentences are easier to comprehend for they are not complex and do not demand greater concentration as is the case for long ones.

2. Completeness- completeness of facts is absolutely necessary. Incomplete communication leads to ineffectiveness of the action to be taken, irrelevancy, misinterpretation and misunderstanding of the message. This is because it leaves a number of questions unanswered.The message should be well organized in such a way that the reader is not in doubt about the details contained in it.

The following aspects should be taken into consideration for communication completeness.

i) While answering a letter include all relevant details and ensure you answer all the questions.

ii) Ensure to consider the five Ws questions i.e. who ?, what?, where ?, when?, why?

3. Conciseness- It is important for your message to be straight to the point but not loading the message with relevant and unnecessary details. Written texts should be as brief as possible but not at the expense of clarity, correctness or courtesy. If the reader feels that s/he is wasting time on your message, she/he may opt to disregard it.

   How to achieve conciseness

   i) Include only relevant facts and details
   ii) Avoid repetition
   iii) Avoid wordy expressions, figure of speech and ambiguous words
   iv) Organize your message well i.e the introduction, the body of the message and the conclusion.
   v) The message should be coherent i.e. it should hold to

4. Consideration- We must show consideration to our readers by:
   i) Adopting the ‘’you’’ attitude- Avoid “I” and “We” in your message. The “you” attitude is highly recommended for it shows respect and consideration for the recipient. It makes the reader see the letter from his point of view.
   ii) Emphasize positive and pleasant statement- In case where one has to send a message of regret, use positive and pleasant words.
   Example of negative expression- “We are sorry to inform you that you have not been admitted to this school”
   Positive expression - “Thank you for your application for a course in Micro-finance. You are however advised that commencement date is July next year.”
   iii) Impart integrity to your message – showing integrity perhaps is the best way of showing consideration. Ethical principles of sincerity and fairness should be observed.

5. Courtesy: this is a considerate and friendly behaviour towards others. The following principles help to promote courtesy;
    i) Answer the letter promptly- answer the letter the same day you receive it.
    ii) Omit irritating negative expressions- i.e. you forgot, you did not, you failed, we regret
    iii) Apologize for an omission; - express your regret for something you have overlooked.
    iv) Thank generally for a favour.
6. Correctness:
    i) Give correct facts- this entails use of correct facts and expressing them in correct language. One should not transmit any message unless they are absolutely sure if its correctness.
    ii) Send message at the right time- message should be transmitted and responded to at the most appropriate time. Outdated information is useless. Message is most effective if sent at the right t time.
    iii) Send message in the correct style- adapt your message to the needs of the receiver. consider his education background, specialized knowledge on the subject etc.

Why does Communication breakdown?

In the previous lecture have learned that communication is an active process that involves giving and receiving ideas, thoughts, opinions, feelings, and attitudes between two or more participants which lead to a response or feedback. However, in the process of the exchange, the message may not be transmitted exactly the same as it is in the mind of the sender, and/or the intended message of the sender is not clearly understood by the receiver. These lead to communication breakdown. Recognizing the different barriers to effective communication is important to be able to avoid communication breakdown. Here are some barriers that may cause breakdown in communication.

What are barriers?

These are those things that act as obstacles to effective communication.

Anything that impedes the free flow of ideas

These barriers act as physical, mental, emotional, psychological blocks and result in failure of communication and/or miscommunication.

Barriers interfere with active listening and careful response. They do not let the receiver pay complete attention to the message. Owing to barriers in communication, you cannot concentrate on what is being told to you, or you may fail to receive the message a hundred percent. These barriers act at physical, mental, emotional, and psychological levels. They contribute to the failure of communication, or, cause miscommunication.

Sources of barriers

Generally, barriers in communication occur whenever one of the elements of communication – the sender, encoding, medium, decoding, receiver, or feedback is defective. There are several types of barriers in the communication process. The following are some of the common barriers in communication :

I. Physical Barriers

a) Noise
b) Sometimes physical barrier blocks effective communication for example, a receiver who wears ear protection probably could not hear someone yelling, "Fire!"
c) Time and Distance. The thousands of miles between New York and Paris and the time-zone difference can complicate communication in a global organization.
d) Human Physical Disorders: The possible disorder affecting communication fall generally into the following categories
   (i) speech and voice defects
   (ii) anxiety – tension reaction such as those involved in stage fright or feelings of inferiority, which noticeably affect speech

(iii) paralysis and diseases;

e) Barriers relating to Channels

(i) Wrong handling of the channel: If a meeting, radio programme or one of the other channels is not used according to the correct procedure and techniques, its potential for carrying a message is dissipated.

(ii) Wrong selection of channels: All channels are not equally useful in attaining a specific objective. Failure to select channels appropriately for the transmission of the message affects the communication process.

(iii) Physical distraction: Failure to avoid physical distraction often obstructs successful message-sending.

(iv) Use of inadequate channels in parallel: The more channels a communicator uses a parallel or at about the same time, the more chances he has of the message getting though and being properly received.

2. Semantic Barriers

Semantic refers to meaning of language used. Semantic is the systematic study of the meaning of different words and signs. The same word can be interpreted by different people in different way according to their mental attitude and understanding, economic, social and economic background.

Semantic distortion can be deliberate or accidental. The message sender should give careful thought to what certain terms will mean to receivers. An advertisement that states "we sell for less" is deliberately ambiguous; it raises this question: less than what? Words may evoke different responses.

Unless the words used to interpret the same way by both the receiver and the sender, communication will not take place.

Semantic barriers are:

a) A symbol or Words with different meaning- A symbol or word can have different meaning e. g the word 'value' can have different meaning as in the following sentences.

1. What is the value of computer education these days?

2. What is the value of this television set?

To some people the word government may mean interference or deficit spending; to others, the same word may mean help, equalization and justice.

b) Difficult level of language: The difficult level of language affects receiver's comprehension. The language used to frame a message must be suited to the intended receivers.

c) The use of jargon is closely related difficult level. The use of jargon with outsiders (non-professionals) is inappropriate, but appropriate with insiders (professionals).

Denotations and Connotations- The literal meaning of a word is called its denotative meaning. A word may have different meaning depending on its denotative and connotative meaning. Connotations arouse qualitative judgment and personal reactions.

d) Faulty translations: the receiver of a message may not assign the same meaning to a word as the transmitter had intended leading to faulty interpretation of words.

e) Poorly expressed messages: No matter how clear the idea is in the mind of the sender of communication, the message may still be marked by poorly chosen words, omissions, lack of coherence, poor organization, awkward sentence structure, platitudes and a failure to clarify its implication. This lack of clarity and precision can be avoided through greater care in encoding the message.

f) Unclarified Assumptions: Sometimes a sender takes for granted knows some of the basic things and therefore it is enough to tell him/ her about the major subject matter. This point of view of the sender is correct to some extent with reference to the daily communications, but it is wrong in case of some special messages.

3. Psychological Barriers

The psychological state of the receiver will influence how the message is received. People's background, perceptions, values, biases, needs and expectations differ.

a) Childhood experiences may result in negative feelings towards authority figures, racial prejudice, and distrust of the opposite sex, or lack of self-confidence.

b) Stress and worries: Family and personal problems, including poor health, alcoholism and emotional strain, may be so upsetting that an employee is unable to concentrate on communication.

c) Lacking confidence: A lack of confidence can be a major barrier to effective communication. Shyness, difficulty being assertive, or lack of self-worth can hinder your ability to make your needs and opinions known. Also a lack of awareness of your own rights and opportunities in a given situation can prevent you from expressing your needs openly.

d) Distrust: For successful communication, the transmitter and the receiver must trust each other. If there is lack of trust between them, the receiver will always derive an opposite meaning from the message.

   Experience on present or past jobs may have created anger, distrust and resentment that speak more loudly in the employees mind than any work-related communication.

e) Low motivation and interest: Many messages never get through because the intended receiver is not motivated to hear the message or is not interested. The challenge to the sender is to frame the message in such a way that it appeals to the needs and interests of the receiver.

f) Attitudes and opinions: If an information agrees with our opinions and attitudes, we tend to receive it favourably. It fits comfortably in the filter of our minds. But if the information disagrees with our views or beliefs, we do not react favourably.

g) Value judgment: In every communication situation, receivers make value judgments by assigning an overall worth to a message prior to receiving the entire communication. Such value judgment may be based on the receivers' evaluation of the communication, or the message's anticipated meaning. Thus a hospital administrator may pay little attention to a memorandum from a nursing leader because 'he's always complaining about something'.

h) Closed mind: A person with a closed mind is very difficult to communicate with because they have already made up their mind about what they believe in.

4. Personal Barriers

Personal barriers include:

a) Selective perception**:** Perception is the process by which individuals organize and interpret their sensory impressions in order to give meaning to their environment. Selective perception occur when people block out new information especially if it conflicts with what they belief. Thus when people receive information, they are apt to

hear only those words that reaffirm their beliefs. Information that conflict with preconceived notions either is not noted or is distorted to confirm their preconception.

b) Premature evaluation: Sometimes the receiver of the information tries to dig out meaning without much thinking at the time of receiving or even before receiving information which can be wrong. This type of evaluation is a hindrance in the exchange of information.

c) Lack of Attention: A barrier in communication exists when the receiver of the message in not paying attention to the receiver.

d) People possess varying levels of communication skills. e.g The ability to listen – varies

e) People use different frames of reference and experiences to interpret the world around them

f) The existence of stereotypes and prejudices can powerfully distort what we perceive about others.

5. Cultural Barriers

Communication can be difficult because of different cultures. Cultures provide people with ways of thinking, ways of seeing, hearing and interpreting the world. Thus the same word can mean different word to different people. For example, translating advertising slogans is very risky. The slogan, 'put a tiger in your tank' by Exxon was very effective in the United States, yet was an insult to the people of Thailand.

Colours have different meaning in various cultures. Black is often associated with death in many Western countries while in the Far East white is the colour of mourning.

In the Chinese culture, words may not convey what people really mean because they want to appear humble. For example, when a promotion is offered, the person may say that he or she is not qualified enough to assume great responsibility. But the expectation is that the superior will urge the subordinate to accept the promotion and mention all the virtues and strengths of the candidate as well as his or her suitability for the new position.

Communication patterns differ in various countries with respect to the degree to which they are explicit or implicit. In countries such as Germany and the United States, one expects a person to mean what they say. The need for precision is illustrated in the popularity of management by

objectives, where goals are stated precisely in quantitative, measurable terms whenever possible. In contrast, Japanese communication is implicit, the meaning has to be inferred e.g. Japanese dislike saying 'no' in communication, instead, they couch a negative answer in ambivalent terms.

Ways in which culture interferes with effective cross cultural understandings include:

i) Cognitive constraints: Cognitive constraints are the way people view the world based on their culture. For example, people in the United States might be inclined to feel superior to many cultures because of the power and prevalence of U.S. culture since World War II. Cognitive constraints can also be based on religion, the area in which you live, the school you went to, or even the books you have read. Basically, cognitive constraints are created by the way people's minds give meaning to the world around them based on the knowledge and perceptions they have obtained. These differ from culture to culture.
ii) Behaviour Constraints: Each culture has its own rules about proper behaviour which affects verbal and non-verbal communication. Whether one looks the other person in the eye or not: whether one says what one means overtly or talk around the issue; how people stand to each other when they are talking- all of these and many more rules of politeness which differ from culture to culture.
iii) Emotional Constraints: Different cultures regulate the display of emotion differently. Each culture has rules that tells us how emotional we can be in a situation. Some cultures get very emotional when they are debating an issue. They yell, they cry, they exhibit their anger, fear, frustrations and other feelings openly. Other cultures try to keep their emotions hidden, exhibiting or sharing only the rational or factual aspect of the situation. Italians are generally open about their emotions, with hugs and kisses alternating between angry shouting and gesturing. British people, however, are more reserved and keep their emotions close at hand. This can cause problems when these approaches meet. The British may think Italians are rude in their emotional wildness, while the Italians may see the British as uptight. This varies in approach between each culture.

Gender distinction barriers: Research by Tannen has shown there are differences between men and women in the way they communicate. Men choose to communicate in a way that maintains status and independence. Women tend to communicate in a way that facilitates relationship

building. They have a preference for connection. Often women use what is defined as rapport talk, and communicate in a way that avoids putting other people down. Tannen's research has identified a number of key distinctions between males' and females' communication:

Getting credit: Men tend to receive more credit for their contributions because they communicate their own accomplishments more often.

Confidence and boasting: Men sometimes tend to be boastful about their capabilities, while women downplay their capabilities. Sometimes this results in men being perceived as more confident.

Asking questions: Typically, men ask fewer questions as they feel it might reflect negatively on them.

Apologies: Women are more likely to say 'I'm sorry' as a way of showing concern, whereas men often perceive it as a sign of weakness.

Guidelines for Improving Communication

Effective communication is the responsibility of all persons in the communication process, who work toward a common aim. The following guidelines can help overcome the barriers to communication:

i) Senders of the message must clarify in their minds what they want to communicate. This means that one of the first steps in communicating is clarifying the purpose of the message and making a plan to achieve the intended end.
ii) Effective communication requires that encoding and decoding be done with symbols that are familiar to the sender and the receiver of the message. Unnecessary technical Jargon should be avoided.
iii) The planning of the communication should not be done in a vacuum. Other people should be consulted and encouraged to participate to collect the facts, analyse the message and select the appropriate media e.g. the manager may ask a colleague to read a memo before

it is distributed. The content of the message should fit the recipient level of knowledge and the organizational climate.

iv) It is important to consider the needs of the receivers of the information. Whenever appropriate one should communicate something that is of value to them.

v) There is a saying that says "the tone makes the music", similarly, in communication the tone of voice, the choice of language and the congruency between what is said and how it is said influences the reactions of the receiver of the message.

vi) **Follow up:** following up involves assuming that you are misunderstood. Whenever possible, you should attempt to determine whether your intended meaning was actually received. This is because meaning is often in the mind of the receiver.

vii) **Regulating information flow**: regulating the flow of communication ensures an optimum flow of information to managers and reduces the likelihood of communication overload. Both the quality and quantity of communication should be regulated. The idea is based on the exception principle of management, which states that only significant deviations from policies and procedures should be brought to the attention of managers.

viii) **Utilizing feedback:** feedback is an important element in effective two-way communication. It provides a channel for receiver's response. Through feedback, the communicator can determine whether the message has been received and it has produced the intended response.

ix) **Empathy**: is the ability to put oneself in other person's role and to assume the viewpoints and emotions of that person. This involves being a listener rather than a talker. Empathy requires communications to place themselves in the receivers' positions and anticipate how the message is likely to be decided.

x) Decoding involves perceptions and the message will be fettered through the perceptions of the receiver. The greater gap between the experiences and background of the communicator and the receiver, the greater is the effort that must be to find a common ground of understanding ground on which there are overlapping fields of experience.

xi) **Be genuine rather than manipulative:** be yourself, honestly and openly. Be honest with yourself, and focus on working well with the people around you and acting with integrity.

a. Feedback from others regarding their perception of you as a means of increasing your self-awareness.

xii) **Focus on others:** Develop your ability to focus on other people, and understand them better by trying to gather knowledge about them, listening to them actively and imagine how you would feel in their situation.

xiii) **Improve Listening Skills:** An individual must be a good listener. Listening is 'half ' of whole communication. When one listens he also carries out concurrent mental interpretation of what he is hearing. Positive outlook goes a long way to ensure effective communication. Important points for good listener are as under:

(a) Do not have preconceived ideas about a subject matter.

(b) Pay full attention to what the sender is saying.

(c) Think as the sender thinks.

(d) Check back as to what you have received.

(e) Give time to take feedback on action taken on the message received.

(f) Keep the principle of "need to know" in mind to avoid information overload.

(g) Do not jump to conclusions.

(h) Do not have a prejudiced mind and take every message independently.

xiv) **Improve Written Skills:** When a message is intended to be sent, it is necessary to identify action addressed and information addressed. The text of the message should be simple and should clearly indicate as to what actions are required to be taken by the receiver. A well written communication in simple language has negligible chances of misinterpretation. Writing good message is an art and it must be practiced overtime. Basic principles of good written message are brevity, clarity and simplicity.

Summary

In this lecture, we have learnt that a communication barrier is any factor that interferes with the achievement of understanding between the sender and the receiver. Because of the complexity of the communication process, many possible barriers or breakdowns can arise. An effective communicator should anticipate and try to avoid the occurrence of these barriers.